Chapter 9.

RE-IMAGINING SECURITY

Adjusting Habits to Contemporary Times

Corrosion is now the new competition. In a world of constraints and risks, nations now penetrate and influence rather than directly confront each other. So, if the threats are different, our defences must be too. And that starts with greater awareness of our times. There was an era when we thought of security essentially as policing, law and order, intelligence and investigation. We would stretch it understandably to counter-insurgency, counter-terrorism and border defences. As an extreme case, our thoughts perhaps extended to military conflict. Today, however, you might want to think that through again. Life is not what it used to be; neither are its challenges.

It is not that these entrenched problems have become less; it is quite the contrary. It is that even as we remain focussed on the abnormal, the ‘normal’ has taken very concerning forms. Every day, all around us, activities and interactions are happening that put our polity and society at risk. Unless we wake up to how much globalization can impact our security, a day may come when we will find ourselves compromised beyond redemption. More powerful nations are struggling with their own versions of this predicament.

Our world has changed profoundly and so, too, must our sense of security. This means looking at the variables of global politics and appreciate what it really means to be in an interdependent and interpenetrative world. The ‘knowledge economy’ that we are now getting accustomed to can generate new metrics of power. The strongest today is increasingly defined as the smartest. And as the epics would confirm, this is not altogether unprecedented.